

- ⑤ The consequences of breaking the oath should appear within the oath itself. “By the sun, moon, and stars, I swear my sword to you lest my hand grow numb and my weapon break when drawn.” If the taker fails to keep her oath, the penalty falls upon her; her hand literally loses feeling and any sword she attempts to take up shatters upon use.

Restoration and Atonement

A changeling who breaks an oath and suffers the penalties may yet change the course of events by petitioning to take an Oath of Atonement. Provided her liege or the person(s) affected by the oath breaking approve, the oath breaker may swear an oath acknowledging her fault and taking upon herself some action intended to compensate for the lapse. The form of atonement, usually dictated by the person or persons offended, may be symbolic or severe, depending on the nature of the oath broken and the results caused by its breaking. The conditions may vary, from making an apology or kissing the offended person's hand or weapon to agreeing to lay down one's life if necessary,

For many changelings, the onus of bearing the foresworn label makes the Oath of Atonement as desirable as water in the desert. A few, however, may take a perverse pride in the label and see the epithet of “foresworn” as a badge of pride. Though many times, foresworn belong to the Unseelie Court or become Unseelie afterwards, just as often Seelie changelings fall prey to the perils of oath breaking. Both Courts tend to look down on those who break faith with them.

Sample Oaths

The system for performing each of the following oaths appears after the oath's wording. While some changelings may rewrite the wording of the oaths to more closely reflect their own sensibilities, the substance of the oath should remain the same and the system described should still apply. Note that these are not the only oaths that exist, and the Storyteller is encouraged to come up with new ones when appropriate. Also, the Dreaming bypasses the kith frailty for pookas, enabling them to speak the words of the oaths truthfully.

⑤ The Oath of Clasped Hands

Blood for blood, bone for bone, life for life, until none walk the earth save we alone, I place my life into your hands, my blood in your veins, my bones as your bones. Hold me well, as I hold you, and I will lend you my strength. Break your bond, and may we both perish. I swear to you friendship by this oath of clasped hands and shared hearts.

System: One of the most serious oaths possible for a changeling, second only to an oath of marriage, if that, this oath belongs only to those changelings who feel a bond for a friend beyond that of mere friendship. To undertake the oath, the oath makers clasp hands around a double-edged blade while saying the words, each player spending a point of Glamour to empower the oath. The mixing of the blood welds together the bond between the two oath makers, strengthening and affirming their friendship. At the completion of the ceremony, the oath makers each gain a Willpower point. If either party breaks the oath, both of them lose two Willpower points. (Note that

their lives do not actually end; some of the Willpower perishes in a symbolic loss of vitality.) In some changeling circles, the breaking of an oath may lead to ritual suicide, but this happens only rarely, and only when such practices are part of historic tradition.

⑤ The Oath of Fealty

In the name of the Dreaming, I swear my loyalty to you, my lord/lady [sometimes the actual name of the lord or lady is inserted here]. As the moon rules the tide, as the rain refreshes the grass, as the sun imparts life to all, so your will becomes my desire. As you command, I will obey; as you request, I will comply. May my service always please you, and may my eyes lose their sight if I invoke your wrath. My heart, my mind, my hands are yours from now until you release me from this oath.

System: The words of this oath constitute the formal Oath of Fealty used in investitures, knightings, and Sainings. This oath requires the player to spend one Willpower point, as well as make a full obeisance that lasts at least as long as it takes to speak the oath and receive a reply to it. This usually entails the speaker of the oath bending one knee in the classic pose of a knight receiving her title. After the oath takes effect, all difficulties to resist any type of mental domination are lowered by two. Breaking the oath results in the loss of three Willpower points. Extreme cases may result in the Dreaming striking the character blind for a year and a day.

⑤ The Oath of Escheat

In the name of the Dreaming, I take you [name of vassal] as my vassal. As the stones, the trees, and the grass belong to the earth, so do you belong to me as one of my house and hearth. I promise to hold you, to guard you, and to keep you. I pledge to honor your service as it deserves, to reward loyalty in kind, and to assure you of shelter in times of need and plenty. As the moon to the seas below, so is my will to yours. With these words, I pledge the Escheat to you.

System: With these words, a ruler formally accepts another fae as a vassal. Usually spoken in connection with and as a response to the Oath of Fealty, it may also serve as the acknowledgement of another fae as a member of the house without conferring any title. When these words are spoken, the speaker loses a point of Glamour and a chimerical gold coin stamped with her visage appears in her hand. The oath becomes binding when the speaker offers and the vassal accepts the coin, which remains in the vassal's possession so long as he keeps his oath. Breaking the oath signifies a departure from the ways of the fae and inflicts the breaker with a Banality point. Those bound to the oath, even if only to one vassal, gain an extra Willpower point per week.

⑤ The Oath of the Accepted Burden

Lay down your burden, and I will take it up. No matter how long the road, how dark the night, or how dangerous the peril, I shall bear this for you or share it with you until all roads come to an end or the need is over. I shall [the task is described here], else may the road cease to lie beneath my feet.

Similar on the surface to a geas, this oath represents a promise to fulfill a certain act, regardless of how large or how small. The oath is made to another person and verifies that the